“respectful” of the religious Jews in attendance. “The policy of the ministry… states that festivals and events paid for with public funds will respect the public at large, which belongs to various communities and sectors,” it said. Days later, the ministry said it would start drafting “modesty guidelines” for future events. The guidelines were never actually written, but the threat had an immediate effect: two weeks later, a Tel Aviv dance troupe (also funded by the ministry) removed a topless number from its latest performance.

There was a prelude of sorts to the modesty guidelines in July, when the Shenkar art and design college outside Tel Aviv hosted an exhibition. One of the paintings, drawn by a student, featured a nude woman; while it did not identify her, her face looked unmistakably like Justice Minister Ayelet Shaked. The president of the college, Yuli Tamir, quickly ordered the painting to be removed.

The artist, Yam Amrani, could not explain the painting’s artistic value, beyond saying that he hoped to “induce discomfort that conveys nihilism”. The editorial board at *Ha’aretz* wrote in his defense, but many of their colleagues were unconvinced. One of the paper’s former correspondents called the painting “cheap and old chauvinism”; Orit Kamir, a law professor at Hebrew University, penned a critical op-ed that called it an “act of shaming”. But Larry Abramson, the head of the art school, resigned in protest. “Who’s to judge? You have to allow art to be seen, even if you don’t like it personally,” he said. “It’s always dangerous when a politician with a vested interest conducts cultural criticism.”

“A liberal state is supposed to be neutral concerning the content of literature, of culture,” Dahan said. “When this distinction is made, it’s basically used to censor, to intimidate actors and writers.”

This view was once shared by the leaders of the Israeli right. Menachem Begin, the first Likud prime minister, argued back in the 1950s that the Knesset should voluntarily limit its own authority. He wanted it to pass a law that would forbid future parliaments from “limiting oral or written freedom of expression or association or other basic civil and human rights.” This view, needless to say, has fallen out of favor—not only with Regev, but with many younger lawmakers and activists on the right. The education ministry (led by Bennett) banned a novel featuring an Arab-Jewish romance from schools, calling it a threat to Jewish identity. Im Tirtzu, a far-right group that has campaigned mercilessly against liberal NGOs, released a